

CHARLES DICKENS (1812-1870)

VISUAL LESSON
CHARLES DICKENS

VIDEO



KEY TOPICS

OPPOSITES

SCIENCE AND TECHNOLOGY

LEAD IN

1 Read how the English writer Zadie Smith describes Dickens' presence in the English culture. Then answer the following questions.

Dickens was everywhere. He was in school and on the shelves at home and in the library. He invented Christmas. He was in politics, influencing changes in labour law, educational law, even copyright law. [...] He was also everywhere I wanted to be: in the theatre, in Italy, in America. Televised versions of his books were on rotation [...] all over Hollywood, in conscious adaptation and unconscious theft.

- Which words reveal Dickens' impressive influence on English literature?
- How does Smith describe Dickens' influence on non-literary fields?
- Has Dickens influenced pop culture? How do you know that?

Share your ideas with the rest of the class.

LISTENING

3 117 Complete Charles Dickens' biography with the following words (1-8). Then listen and check.

loneliness | work | Victoria | education | magazines | eight | imprisoned | novel

Who was Charles Dickens?

Dickens was born in 1812 in Portsmouth. The second of 1 siblings, at the age of nine he was sent to school but his formal 2 proved to be short. When he was about twelve his father was 3 for outstanding debts and was joined by most of the family, which forced Charles to 4 ten-hour days in a London factory making shoe polish. The young Charles suffered three years of terrible 5 and hardship, which would serve as material for him in his future work. He began his writing career as a journalist and in 1833 became the parliamentary reporter for *The Morning Chronicle*. He published a series of very successful sketches using the pseudonym 'Boz', *Sketches by Boz* (1833-36), followed by *The Pickwick Papers* (1836), his first 6 and the start of his brilliant, prolific career. Dickens produced an immense number of novels, which were published initially as instalments in 7 and then as complete books, as well as an autobiography and regular contributions to periodicals. He appears to have been a man of inexhaustible energy, who found time to travel to America for a lecture tour campaigning against slavery, as well as to France, Switzerland, and Italy. He also wrote for the theatre and performed in front of Queen 8 in 1851. He died in 1870 and was buried in Westminster Abbey.

VOCABULARY Lab

2 Find the English translation of the following words (1-8) in Dickens' biography.

- | | |
|-----------------------|-------------------|
| 1. fratelli e sorelle | 5. stenti |
| 2. debiti | 6. corrispondente |
| 3. fabbrica | 7. puntate |
| 4. solitudine | 8. contributi |



↑ Charles Dickens in His Study by William Powell Frith (1859), oil on canvas, Victoria and Albert Museum, London.

Main works

Dickens was a very prolific writer and his literary production, which includes an incredible variety of titles, can be divided into three main phases:

- The Early Phase (1836-1842)**, characterised by a humorous tone, melodrama and social satire. This phase includes Dickens' first published book, *The Pickwick Papers* (1836-7), an episodic novel exemplifying Dickens' humour, based on the creation of characters with some distinctive peculiarity of speech, physical appearance or gesture, and on the representation of comic situations involving them. Dickens' next novel, *Oliver Twist* (1837-9) is perhaps his most famous and most popular and marks the beginning of social criticism, touching upon the exploitation of children and the cruelty of the workhouses.
- The Middle Phase (1843-1850)**, showing the emergence of a deeper sense of social criticism. This phase includes heterogeneous works such as *A Christmas Carol* (1843), a ghost story featuring the conversion of a miser to the spirit of Christmas; *Dombey and Son* (1846), which attacks the greed for money and power, and marks a more sombre mood in Dickens' literary production; *David Copperfield* (1849-50), a novel following its protagonist's growth from childhood to adulthood and representing Dickens' most autobiographical work.
- The Mature Phase (1850-1870)**, in which social criticism becomes darker and bitterer, including works where Dickens reflects on the evils of society, the fallacy of legal systems, or the inconsistency of social revolutions. Dickens' mature works include *Bleak House* (1852-53), a satire on the English administration of justice; *Hard Times* (1854), bearing on education and on the hardships of the working class during the Industrial Revolution; *A Tale of Two Cities* (1859), a historical novel set before and during the French Revolution; *Great Expectations* (1860-61), a novel about the influence that sudden wealth can have on a young man's moral growth.

Narrative structure, language and style

Dickens' novels are populated by characters who are often portrayed as caricatures embodying vices or virtues. Rather than making them 'fixed', the typical quality of Dickens' characters turns them into some of the most memorable characters in English literature. Dickens wrote very copiously and quickly, generally under pressure both from his publishers and through his own need for money, and the episodic nature of his novels always guaranteed a succession of moments of great tension. Technically, Dickens needed to maintain interest from one episode to another: he did so by ending each episode with a dramatic turn of events that provoked suspense in readers, who would naturally buy the next issue to learn how the story continued. This explains the abundance of characters, of climaxes and of improbable coincidences in the plots and subplots. Dickens also had to consider his readers' tastes (often inclined to sentimentality) which accounts for his indulgence in melodrama in many of his works.

BEYOND THE BOOKSHELF



Dickens' popularity among filmmakers is second to none in English literature. The inventive plots, the abundance of narrative details, and the grotesque and visually compelling particulars that characterise Dickens' novels have made them perfect to be adapted into films. The most popular among the recent film adaptations of Dickens' novels include *Oliver Twist* (2005) by Roman Polanski, the 3D adaptation of *A Christmas Carol* (2009) by Robert Zemeckis and the TV mini-series based on *Great Expectations* (2023).



↑ A scene from the film *The Personal History of David Copperfield* (2019) directed by Armando Iannucci. Starring Morfydd Clark as Clara and Dev Patel as David Copperfield.

WORKS TIMELINE



The main themes of Dickens' novels

- 1. Social inequalities:** almost all of Dickens' novels highlight the **inequalities** characterising Victorian society, with an emphasis on class struggle, child labour, and the harsh living conditions of the working class. **Poverty** is a particularly pervasive theme in Dickens' production and is often related to a lack of human rights, vulnerability, and extreme exploitation.
- 2. Redemption:** Dickens' characters have many incredible adventures, which cause **deep transformations** in them, often leading them to gain self-awareness, embrace compassion and understand the importance of change.
- 3. Family bonds:** Dickens' novels frequently highlight the importance of social bonds among characters. Being part of a **family** or a **social community** is vital for helping individuals face the struggles of life; being deprived of their fundamental 'bonds' makes individuals vulnerable and fragile.
- 4. Corruption and power:** in many of Dickens' works, the **thirst for power** is a driving force that guides characters' actions, turning them into grotesque individuals who give up their humanity to obtain power, often through questionable means and actions.

IELTS FIRST Reading and Use of English | Part 2

For questions (1-8), read the text below and think of the word which best fits each gap. Use only one word in each gap. There is an example at the beginning (0 = of).

Dickens' legacy. The frequency of use of the adjective 'Dickensian' is a clear indication **0** of the impact and influence that Charles Dickens **1** had on English society and on the English language, placing the writer almost in the **2** league in terms of familiarity as Shakespeare, with characters who have become synonyms for character types. His influence on the English language is multi-layered and articulated. **3** of all, Dickens had a fundamental role in spreading words that already existed in English, but were totally unknown. A clear example is represented by the word 'boredom', **4** certainly existed before Dickens, but came into common usage after his novel *Bleak House*. Another aspect of Dickens' influence on the English language regards his use of popular slang expressions, which have now **5** common in English: an example could be the word 'butter-fingers' (contained in *The Pickwick Papers*), an expression **6** today in colloquial English to refer to someone who is so clumsy with objects that they cannot hold them in their hands. It was with proper names, **7**, that Dickens proved all of his genius: he invented names that were so effective that they became legendary. 'Scrooge' is probably the **8** famous of Dickens' names: it was coined for the protagonist of *A Christmas Carol*, but it soon became a name in itself meaning a 'miserable and mean person'.

CHECKPOINT

Answer the following questions.

- What event forced Charles Dickens to have first-hand experience of working in a factory?
- Which of Dickens' novels are characterised by social criticism?
- What are the works belonging to the mature phase of Dickens' literary production?
- How did Dickens keep his readers' interest alive in his novels?
- What is the meaning of the term 'Scrooge'?



↑ 'Ebenezer Scrooge visited by Marley's ghost'. Illustration by John Leech (1843) for *A Christmas Carol* by Charles Dickens.



↑ 'The Fat Boy', a character of *The Pickwick Papers*. Illustration by Joseph Clayton Clarke (Kyd) published in *Characters Sketches from Charles Dickens* (1889).

ORACY Lab

Summarise the key concepts of Dickens' life and literary production using the following bullet points to guide your thinking.

- journalism
- factory
- episodic structure
- social criticism
- main themes

GETTING TO KNOW

Oliver Twist or The Parish Boy's Progress (1837-39)



LEAD IN

Read this definition of 'social inequality' by sociologist Ashley Crossman. Then answer the following questions.

Social inequality [...] can manifest in a variety of ways, like income and wealth inequality, unequal access to education and cultural resources, and differential treatment by the police and judicial system, among others.

- What aspects of 'social inequality' do you think Dickens identified in the Victorian world?
- If you were a writer today, what aspects of 'social inequality' would you condemn?

Share your ideas with the rest of the class.

VOCABULARY Lab

Match the Italian words (1-8) with their English translation (a-h). Write a letter in the boxes.

- | | | |
|-------------------------|--------------------------|---------------|
| 1. orfano | ☐ | a. apprentice |
| 2. parto | ☐ | b. burglary |
| 3. ospizio per i poveri | ☐ | c. childbirth |
| 4. fame | ☐ | d. hunger |
| 5. apprendista | ☐ | e. orphan |
| 6. ladri | ☐ | f. pickpocket |
| 7. borseggiatore | ☐ | g. thieves |
| 8. furto | ☐ | h. workhouse |

Oliver Twist or The Parish Boy's Progress - The plot

Complete the text with the missing words (1-8). Use the words of the Vocabulary Lab.

Oliver Twist was born in a workhouse. He is an **1**, son of an unknown father, and his mother dies in **2**. Conditions in the **3** are terrible and the boys constantly suffer from **4**. When Oliver asks for more food at the end of the evening meal, he provokes a furious reaction from the officials who send him away to work as an **5** for an undertaker¹. Oliver runs away to London, where he becomes involved with a gang of **6**, led by Fagin. On his first mission as a **7**, Oliver is arrested but then rescued and looked after by Mr Brownlow, the victim of the theft. Fagin's gang of criminals capture Oliver and return him to Fagin. Oliver is forced to take part in a **8** with Sikes, Fagin's brutal accomplice. Oliver is shot at and abandoned by the gang. He is taken in by Mrs Maylie, who nurses Oliver back to health. Oliver spends an idyllic summer with Mrs Maylie and her adopted niece, Rose. Nancy, a prostitute with a kind heart who is part of Fagin's gang, discovers why Fagin and his gang are so determined to recapture Oliver. Monks, one of Fagin's accomplices, is in reality Oliver's half-brother: both are sons of a wealthy father, who left most of his fortune to Oliver's mother, Agnes Fleming. Monks plotted to kill Oliver to get the entire inheritance. It also emerges that Rose is Agnes's younger sister and therefore Oliver's aunt. Nancy is brutally murdered by Sikes for revealing this information to Rose and Mr Brownlow. Sikes dies as he is trying to escape arrest. Fagin is caught and sentenced to be hanged and Monks dies in prison. Oliver, who now knows his true identity and receives his share of his father's inheritance, is adopted by Mr Brownlow and can finally enjoy a peaceful life in the countryside.

¹ undertaker: impresario funebre



↑ A scene from the film *Oliver Twist* (2005) by Roman Polanski, starring Barney Clark as Oliver.

The main themes

• **Poverty:** through *Oliver Twist* Dickens expresses his anger at the living conditions of the poor and the iniquity of the Poor Law of 1834, which dictated that **public charity was to be administered through workhouses**. In Victorian England poverty was seen mainly as a sin and under the terms of the Poor Law poor people could only receive assistance if they lived and worked in workhouses. Conditions were extremely harsh to discourage the poor from relying on public charity. Families were divided and children forced to do hard physical work and severely undernourished. In his novel Dickens shows that the only possible alternative to the suffering and humiliation of life in the workhouse, where the hypocritical middle class saw themselves as paragons of Christian virtue as they gave charity to the poor, was a life of crime or prostitution.

• **Hypocrisy of Victorian England:** *Oliver Twist* contains innumerable merciless descriptions of the **cruelty and hypocrisy** of Victorian England, a land of misery where Oliver's good qualities truly stand out and are amplified. The best example of Victorian hypocrisy is represented by the system that legalised **workhouses**: these institutions are only supposed to be charitable initiatives to support the needy; in reality, they are 'ghettos' where Victorian society confines unwelcomed members of the community, forcing them to live in conditions of aberration and degradation.

• **Purity and reward:** Dickens' novel makes Oliver encounter a variety of different circumstances and people. 'Twisted' around – as his name suggests – by all of them, Oliver stands out as a child with a **pure heart** and a **determined spirit**, two qualities that are ultimately rewarded when, at the end of the novel, he finds his proper place in society and leads a comfortable life in a country house. Oliver's happy ending comes because of a process of self-discovery, through which Oliver manages to find his true identity. In this phase of his literary production Dickens' social criticism does not lead to any reform or change in the Victorian mindset as Oliver simply returns to his rightful status.



↑ A scene from the film *Oliver Twist* (2005) by Roman Polanski, starring Ben Kingsley as Fagin.

#KEYTOPICS OPPOSITES

Social inequality. In *Oliver Twist*, Dickens explores the many contrasts underpinning Victorian society and emphasises their effects on people experiencing poverty. In the novel, Dickens focuses on the representation of **the impact of the Industrial Revolution**, whose triumph in terms of progress came at a very high cost if we consider the terrible conditions of life for the poor, who were forced to live in squalid conditions where child labour, crime, and exploitation were the norm, forcing them to embrace abjection and degradation.

REFLECT & DISCUSS

4 Answer the following questions.

- How does Dickens challenge Victorian people's view on 'poverty' in *Oliver Twist*?
- How does Dickens portray crime and moral degradation in the novel?
- Do you think writers and artists can promote or accelerate social change through their works?

ORACY Lab

5 Use the following guiding questions to prepare for an oral test on Dickens' *Oliver Twist*.

- Where is Dickens' novel set?
- Why is Oliver Twist sent away from the workhouse?
- How does Oliver Twist end up in the care of Mr Brownlow?
- How does Dickens describe the impact of the Industrial Revolution on the poor in *Oliver Twist*?

WRITING Lab

6 Summarise how *Oliver Twist* expresses Dickens' view on social inequality.

Oliver Twist or The Parish Boy's Progress (1837-39)



A desperate plea for more

LEAD IN

1 Look at this chart, showing how wealth is distributed across the world. Then answer the following questions.

- Who owns 38% of the world's wealth?
- How much wealth on average does 50% of the world population own?
- What contradiction does this chart show about the distribution of the world's wealth?

Share your ideas with the rest of the class.

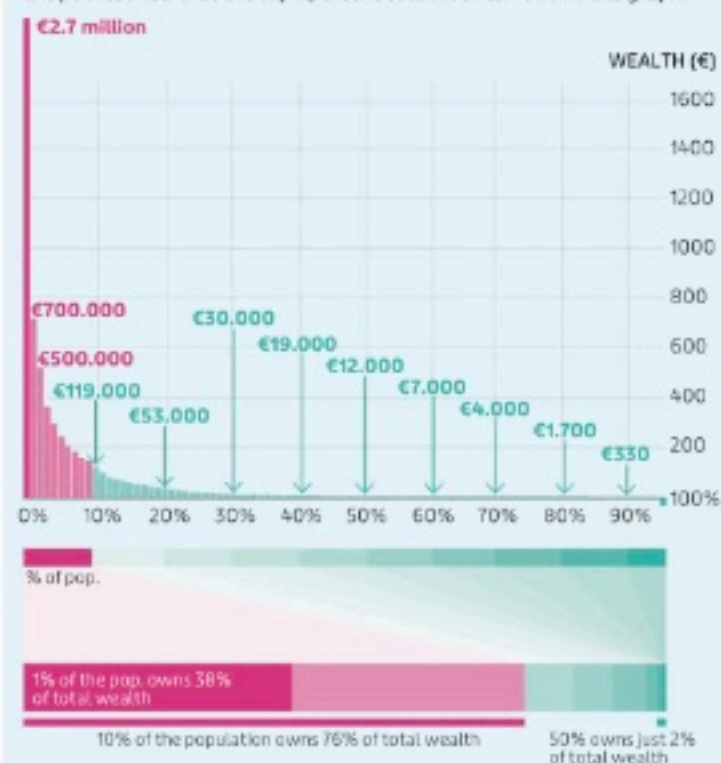
VOCABULARY Lab

2 Complete the table of adjectives and nouns. Check your answers by referring to the text below.

ADJECTIVE	NOUN	ADJECTIVE	NOUN
	festivity	miserable	
starving		astonished	
hungry		fearful	
	desperation	horrified	

OFF THE CHARTS

The richest 1 percent of the world's population is so much wealthier than the poorest half that the top 1 percent column doesn't fit on this graph.



Source: World Inequality Report 2022 by the World Inequality Lab



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In this well-known passage, taken from Chapter 2, Oliver 'dares' to ask for some more food, producing a series of unpredictable and grotesque consequences.

The room in which the boys were fed, was a large stone hall, with a copper¹ at one end: out of which the master, dressed in an apron² for the purpose, and assisted by one or two women, ladled³ the gruel⁴ at mealtimes. Of this festive composition each boy had one porringer⁵, and no more — except on occasions of great public rejoicing, when he had two 5 ounces and a quarter⁶ of bread besides. The bowls never wanted washing⁷. The boys polished them with their spoons till they shone again; and when they had performed this operation (which never took very long, the spoons being nearly as large as the bowls), they would sit staring at the copper, with such eager eyes, as if they could have devoured the very bricks of which⁸ it was composed; employing themselves, meanwhile, in sucking their fingers most assiduously, with the view of catching up any stray splashes of gruel that might have been cast thereon. Boys have generally excellent appetites. Oliver Twist and his companions suffered the tortures of slow starvation for three months: at last they got so voracious and wild with hunger, that one boy, who was

- copper: pentolone di rame
- apron: grembiule
- ladled: versava col mestolo
- gruel: pappa d'avena
- porringer: scodella
- 5 ounces and a quarter: un otto e mezzo
- never wanted washing: non avevano mai bisogno di essere lavate
- the very bricks of which: i mattoni stessi di cui

tall for his age, and hadn't been used to that sort of thing (for his father had kept a small cook-shop), hinted darkly to his companions, that unless he had another basin of gruel per diem, he was afraid he might some night happen to eat the boy who slept next him, who happened to be a weakly youth of tender age. He had a wild, hungry eye; and they implicitly believed him.

A council was held; lots were cast⁹ who should walk up to the master after supper that evening, and ask for more; and it fell to Oliver Twist.

The evening arrived; the boys took their places. The master, in his cook's uniform, stationed himself at the copper; his pauper¹⁰ assistants ranged themselves behind him; the gruel was served out; and a long grace¹¹ was said over the short commons¹². The gruel disappeared; the boys whispered to each other, and winked¹³ at Oliver; while his next neighbours nudged him¹⁴. Child as he was, he was desperate with hunger, and reckless¹⁵ with misery. He rose from the table; and advancing to the master, basin and spoon in hand, said: somewhat alarmed at his own temerity:

'Please, sir, I want some more.'

The master was a fat, healthy man; but he turned very pale. He gazed in stupefied astonishment on the small rebel for some seconds, and then clung for support to the copper. The assistants were paralysed with wonder; the boys with fear.

'What!' said the master at length, in a faint voice.

'Please, sir,' replied Oliver, 'I want some more.'

The master aimed a blow at Oliver's head with the ladle¹⁶; pinioned him¹⁷ in his arm; and shrieked aloud for the beadle¹⁸.

The board were sitting in solemn conclave, when Mr Bumble rushed into the room in great excitement, and addressing the gentleman in the high chair, said,

'Mr Limbkins, I beg your pardon, sir! Oliver Twist has asked for more!'

There was a general start. Horror was depicted on every countenance.

'For MORE!' said Mr Limbkins. 'Compose yourself, Bumble, and answer me distinctly. Do I understand that he asked for more, after he had eaten the supper allotted by the dietary?' 'He did, sir,' replied Bumble.

'That boy will be hung¹⁹,' said the gentleman in the white waistcoat. 'I know that boy will be hung.'

Nobody controverted the prophetic gentleman's opinion. An animated discussion took place. Oliver was ordered into instant confinement; and a bill was next morning pasted on the outside of the gate, offering a reward of five pounds to anybody who would take Oliver Twist off the hands of the parish. In other words, five pounds and Oliver Twist were offered to any man or woman who wanted an apprentice to any trade, business, or calling.

- 9 lots were cast: si tirò a sorte
10 pauper: poveri
11 grace: preghiera di ringraziamento (per il cibo)
12 commons: il cibo (che si mangia in una mensa)
13 winked at: strizzarono l'occhio
14 nudged him: gli davano del colpetti
15 reckless: incosciente
16 ladle: mestolo
17 pinioned him: lo immobilizzò
18 beadle: sagrestano
19 will be hung (hanged): finirà impiccato

↓ 'Oliver Twist asks for more'. Illustration by George Cruikshank for the first edition (1837-39) of *Oliver Twist* by Charles Dickens.



COMPREHENSION

3 Read the text and find evidence to explain:

- where the action takes place;
- what children normally eat in the workhouse;
- what the other boys want Oliver to do;
- what type of reaction Oliver's request provokes;
- what eventually happens to Oliver.

ANALYSIS & INTERPRETATION

4 Focus on ll. 1-13. What details suggest that the boys were starving?

5 Find elements in ll. 13-27 to support the following statements.

- Hunger provokes irrational reactions among the children.
- Oliver sacrifices himself for the benefit of the other boys.
- Oliver's request is unusual.

6 The last part of the passage (ll. 28-50) is characterised by the use of hyperboles (or 'exaggerations'). Can you find them? Focus on:

- the master's reaction to Oliver's request;
- the assistants' feelings;
- the boys' feelings.

You can find the definition in your booklet *Literary Skills*.

7 What does everybody think will happen to Oliver?

8 What effect do hyperboles produce? Tick as appropriate.

- They enhance the grotesque atmosphere of the passage.
- They underline the absurdity of the boys' conditions.
- They make Oliver's request sound ridiculous.

9 Consider the process used by the boys to choose the boy to ask the master for some food.

- What steps were taken to choose Oliver as their spokesperson?
- What was Dickens suggesting by mentioning the solemnity of this process? Choose the correct option.
 - Oliver was a brave boy.
 - The boy's request was exceptional and potentially dangerous.
 - The boys liked formal requests.

10 Dickens described Oliver as a 'small rebel'. Can you explain why he can be considered a rebel?



← John Howard Davies as Oliver in *Oliver Twist* (1948) directed by David Lean.

#KEYTOPICS OPPOSITES

The price of desperation. The passage describes some of the most urgent contradictions of Victorian society through contrasting opposites. **The terrible hunger affecting the poor children** living in the workhouse is heightened by the evident abundance in which their master – a 'fat, healthy man' (l. 29) lives. Oliver and the boys are powerless, and their inferiority is taken advantage of by the world of adults, who exercise their superiority by reducing them to beggars. The strict and inhuman rules of the workhouses are represented as the leading cause of the 'social rebellion' started by Oliver, showing that desperation inevitably leads to contrasts and turmoils. **The contradictions of the age** are summarised by the contrast between the innocence of the boys, who maintain their purity despite the dehumanising conditions they endure, and **the corruption of the world** surrounding them.

REFLECT & DISCUSS

11 Answer the following questions.

- What failures of Victorian society does Dickens criticise through the contrast between hunger and abundance in the passage?
- How does the power imbalance between the boys and the adults in the passage mirror how social hierarchies worked in the Victorian Age? How does Oliver challenge these contradictions?
- If you were one of the children in the passage, would you act like Oliver or like one of the other boys? Why?

DEBATE

12 You are going to debate the following motion.

Oliver Twist is a foolish rebel not a heroic character.

Divide the class in two teams.

- Team A – the Rebels – will support the motion.
- Team B – the Heroes – will argue against the motion.

Both teams might consider the following ideas.

- The poor should accept and be grateful for any help they receive.
- We cannot judge the past by the values of the present.
- It is better to act with courage even if risks are great.
- Rebellion is never a solution – we must look for reform instead.
- Poverty is the result of an unwillingness to work hard.

OPPOSITES



KEY TOPICS



The scandal of child labour

In Dickens' *Oliver Twist* the theme of children's exploitation plays a crucial role, allowing the novel to be a powerful instrument of social criticism. Child labour was undoubtedly one of the darkest contrasts of the Victorian Age, revealing the opposition between the age's tension towards progress and expansion and the hypocritical lack of recognition of fundamental human rights to the weakest components of society. Despite its aberrant nature, child labour remains a persistent plague in a vast number of countries, where children are exploited in various sectors of the economy, such as agriculture, mining, and manufacturing.



↑ Another scene from the film *Oliver Twist* (1948) directed by David Lean.

LEAD IN

1 Focus on this quote by the American politician Alexis Herman. Then answer the following questions.

“If we can't begin to agree on fundamentals, such as the elimination of the most abusive forms of child labor, then we really are not ready to march forward into the future.”

1. What is 'fundamental' according to Herman?
2. Why is child labour preventing humanity from moving forward?

IELTS Listening | Summary completion

2 Listen and complete the notes below. Write no more than three words for each answer.

What is child labour? Child labour means work that children are 1 to perform or that can be hazardous. It contrasts with activities that can help children 2 like light housework or taking a summer holiday job. In its worst forms, child labour can amount to 3 or similar practices. In some places children may be forcibly recruited into 4 Children may be forced to work in an 5 environment or exposed to hazardous substances. Child labour is still a problem today. Global estimates indicate that about 6 children were engaged in child labour in 2020. This number corresponds to nearly 7 children globally. It is most prevalent in 8 countries yet more than 9 of all child labour occurs in middle-income countries.

REFLECT & DISCUSS

3 Answer the following questions.

1. What similarities can you find between Dickens' depiction of 'child labour' in the Victorian Age and what it is in the contemporary world?
2. What kind of work did children do in the Victorian Age? What do they do in today's world?
3. Why were children forced to work in the Victorian Age?
4. What has changed in terms of children's rights since Dickens' time? What international organisations work to protect the rights of children worldwide?



Shattered innocence

Child Labour

Child Labour is a poignant reflection on the exploitation of children, forced to trade their innocence for tools of labour. The poem highlights the silent suffering of young lives, while questioning the societal norms that allow this injustice to persist.

- Who has handed over the iron wands,
Hammers, spanners to flowery hands?
Who has killed all the twinkling worms,
Snatching toys and dolls of fairylands?
5 Who knows how many sons of dream,
Go asleep, longing for milk and cream,
And motherhood with a stone of patience,
Stifles in the heart the emerging scream?
Then who will light the lamp to shine,
10 Delete and demolish the heinous line,
Drawn to divide the great and small;
Clean the path of the world to refine?

< Children are often forced to use workers' tools instead of toys.

< Child labour deprives children of their dreams and forces mothers to live in anguish.

< The poet wonders when the torture of child labour will end and a new, more just world will emerge.

Shahida Latif is a Pakistani poet, reformer, and writer. She has published several collections of poems in Urdu, her native language. In 2013 the Government of Pakistan gave her the Pride of Performance Award for her literary accomplishments.



REFLECT & DISCUSS

1 Answer the following questions.

1. What elements in the poem make you think the poet is talking about children?
2. How do you know the poem is about 'child labour'?



REFLECT ON YOURSELF

2 Answer the following questions.

1. What was your childhood like compared to the cases described in the poem?
2. Have you ever found yourself in a situation in which you felt your dreams had been forcibly suppressed or ignored?
3. In the poem, there is a sense of lost innocence and stifled dreams. Have you ever experienced or witnessed a situation where someone's potential was suppressed, or dreams were unfulfilled?
4. The poem ends with the idea that the world needs to be fixed and made better. What actions would you start to take in order to ignite this process of transformation?

WRITING Lab SHORT ESSAY

3 What happens to children when they are forced to work at a very young age? Why is 'labour' detrimental to their growth? Use the Internet to find enough information to answer these two questions and write a short essay (max. 250 words) to present your findings.

TAKE ACTION

4 June 12th is World Day Against Child Labour. Use the Internet to find more information about this very important event and write a speech to convince the Head of your school to support your intention to have a school-wide celebration of this event.



GETTING TO KNOW...

Hard Times (1854)

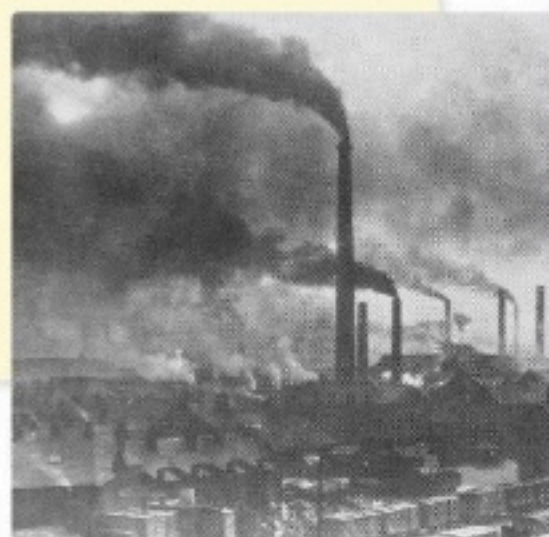


LEAD IN

1 Read Dickens' description of Coketown, the imaginary city where the events in *Hard Times* take place.

It was a town of machinery and tall chimneys, out of which interminable serpents of smoke trailed themselves for ever and ever, and never got uncoiled¹. It had a black canal in it, and a river that ran purple with ill-smelling dye², and vast piles of building full of windows where there was a rattling³ and a trembling all day long, and where the piston of the steam-engine worked monotonously up and down, like the head of an elephant in a state of melancholy madness. It contained several large streets all very like one another, and many small streets still more like one another, inhabited by people equally like one another, who all went in and out at the same hours, with the same sound upon the same pavements, to do the same work, and to whom every day was the same as yesterday and tomorrow, and every year the counterpart of the last and the next.

Now look at this picture, representing the city of Widnes in the 19th century. What elements of Coketown can you find in it? Focus on the smoke, the buildings and the monotony of the landscape. Share your ideas with the rest of the class.



- 1 never got uncoiled: non si srotolavano mai
2 dye: tintura
3 rattling: sferragliamento

LISTENING

2 122 Complete the text with the following words. Then listen and check.

family | mistakes | children | theft | marriage | facts

Hard Times - The plot

Dickens' *Hard Times* (1854) is set in **Coketown**, a fictional town based on Preston in the north of England. Thomas Gradgrind, an inflexible advocate of **Utilitarianism**, raises his two 1 _____, Louisa and Tom, to reject any form of imagination and enjoyment in favour of 'hard facts'. As a supporter of Utilitarianism, Gradgrind despises the idea that love should be at the basis of marriage, and has his daughter marry Josiah Bounderby, a factory owner who is 30 years older than her. Louisa's 2 _____ proves to be an extremely unhappy one, and she runs back to her family. Old Mr Gradgrind begins to understand his 3 _____ and protects Louisa from her husband. Meanwhile Louisa's brother Tom, who has grown into a dishonest, selfish man, steals money from Bounderby's bank. Stephen, an innocent worker in Bounderby's factory, is unjustly accused of the 4 _____ and eventually dies as a consequence. Gradgrind and Louisa, realising that Tom is responsible for the theft, finally succeed in getting him out of the country and away from justice. At the end of the story Gradgrind gives up his philosophy of 5 _____ and devotes himself to helping the poor. Tom repents his actions but dies without managing to see his family again. Bounderby, the real villain of the story, dies alone in the streets of Coketown, while Louisa, who never marries again, finds happiness in the love of her friends and 6 _____.



↑ A scene from the BBC version of *Hard Times* (1994) adapted by Peter Barnes.

The main themes

- **The failure of Utilitarian philosophy:** in *Hard Times*, Dickens fiercely attacks Utilitarianism. In the new Utilitarian schools established by philanthropists such as Gradgrind, students were crowded in **huge schoolrooms**, where they were **treated like numbers** rather than real people, forced into conformity through harsh discipline, and discouraged from expressing their own personalities. This was in accord with the need to supply **skilled but obliging workers** to the new factory system that had come about with the Industrial Revolution.
- **Social class and inequality:** the novel depicts **the massive divide** between the limited number of wealthy industrialists and the vast number of poor people who are deprived of their fundamental rights and cannot gain a better position in society as the industrial system keeps them enslaved. **Industrialisation** is seen as a **dangerous process** that dehumanises people and turns them into mechanical components of a vast machine whose main aim is to produce goods and wealth. The denunciation of the **alienating effects** of the modern 'industrial' system is one of the novel's most powerful elements of social criticism.
- **Compassion and empathy:** Dickens juxtaposes **grotesque characters** such as Gradgrind with **more humane characters** such as Sissy Jupe, one of the students in Gradgrind's school, who believe in the power of compassion and have a high degree of emotional intelligence. By contrasting them with their exact opposites Dickens makes the **values of compassion and empathy** shine and suggests that only if they cultivate these virtues will humans be able to build a fair society for all.

KEY TOPICS SCIENCE AND TECHNOLOGY

The impact of industrialisation on people. Dickens shows the effects of the industrial system on human beings especially through the depiction of **the alienating effects** of an education based on the principles of **Utilitarianism**. Gradgrind's school is a grotesque example of an educational institution that has been transformed into a place where children are turned into **machine-like beings**. A school like the one run by Mr Gradgrind is not an institution that enables students to build a better future for themselves, but a place in which coercion is used to enslave and subjugate people. The monotonous factuality of Gradgrind's school is **mirrored** by the structure of **the city of Coketown**, a polluted, alienating, and dehumanising environment where everything – including its own inhabitants – are supposed to act like efficient and brainless machines.

REFLECT & DISCUSS

3 Answer the following questions.

1. How do you imagine the life of the inhabitants of Coketown?
2. What dangers does Dickens think uncontrolled industrialisation might imply for individuals and society?
3. Do you think Dickens' vision of the dehumanising effects of industrialisation and progress was prophetic?

Focus on...
UTILITARIANISM

Utilitarianism is a materialistic philosophy founded by **Jeremy Bentham** (1748-1832). This theory encouraged reform and fought to extend education to all, but at the same time excluded aspects of education, such as imagination and the full development of the individual.



↑ 'Mr Gradgrind finds his children Tom and Louisa peeping inside the circus tent'. Illustration by Charles Stanley Reinhart (2011).

VOCABULARY Lab

4 Divide the ten words into two groups: positive and negative meanings.

enjoyment | selfish | imagination | unhappy |
love | happiness | dishonest | innocent | inflexible |
villain

CHECKPOINT

5 Use the following keywords to write summarising sentences about Dickens' *Hard Times*.

- utilitarianism
- social inequality
- education
- empathy
- industrialisation

ORACY Lab PRESENTATION

6 Create a mindmap with the information of the Checkpoint and use it to make an oral presentation of the main features of Dickens' *Hard Times*.

Hard Times (1854)



The doctrine of facts

LEAD IN

1 Think about a school. Then answer the following questions.

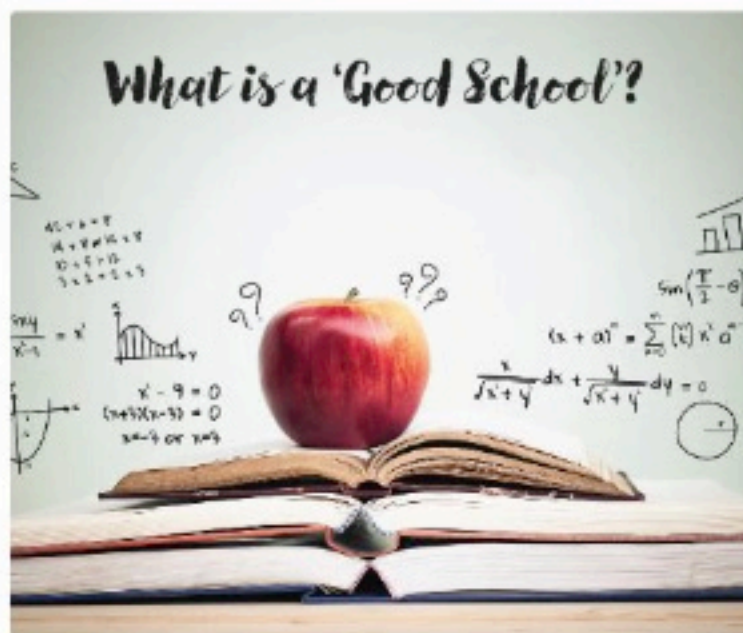
1. What attributes should it have to be considered 'good'?
2. Is your school a 'good school'?
3. What aspects of your school would you improve to really make it better?

Share your ideas with the rest of the class.

VOCABULARY Lab

2 Find the English translation of these parts of the body (1-8) in the passage below.

- | | | | |
|-----------|-----------------|------------|-----------|
| 1. indice | 3. sopracciglia | 5. capelli | 7. spalle |
| 2. fronte | 4. bocca | 6. gambe | 8. gola |



123 The passage you are about to read shows Mr Gradgrind, the headmaster of the school in Coketown, giving a lecture on the importance of fact-based education.

'NOW, what I want is, Facts. Teach these boys and girls nothing but Facts. Facts alone are wanted in life. Plant nothing else, and root out everything else. You can only form the minds of reasoning animals upon Facts: nothing else will ever be of any service to them. This is the principle on which I bring up my own children, and this is the principle on which I bring up these children. Stick to Facts¹, sir!'

The scene was a plain, bare, monotonous vault² of a schoolroom, and the speaker's square forefinger³ emphasized his observations by underscoring every sentence with a line⁴ on the schoolmaster's sleeve⁵. The emphasis was helped by the speaker's square wall of a forehead, which had his eyebrows for its base, while his eyes found commodious cellars⁶ in two dark caves, overshadowed by the wall. The emphasis was helped by the speaker's mouth, which was wide, thin, and hard set⁷. The emphasis was helped by the speaker's voice, which was inflexible, dry, and dictatorial. The emphasis was helped by the speaker's hair, which bristled⁸ on the skirts of his bald head, a plantation of firs⁹ to keep the wind from its shining surface, all covered with knobs¹⁰, like the crust of a plum pie, as if the head had scarcely warehouse-room for the hard facts stored inside. The speaker's obstinate carriage¹¹, square coat, square legs, square shoulders, — nay¹², his very neckcloth¹³, trained to take him by the throat with an unaccommodating grasp¹⁴, like a stubborn¹⁵ fact, as it was, — all helped the emphasis.

'In this life, we want nothing but Facts, sir; nothing but Facts!'

The speaker, and the schoolmaster, and the third grown person present, all backed a little, and swept with their eyes¹⁶ the inclined plane of little vessels¹⁷ then and there arranged in order, ready to have imperial gallons¹⁸ of facts poured into them until they were full to the brim¹⁹.

1. Stick to Facts: Attenetevi ai fatti
2. vault: scantinato
3. forefinger: indice
4. with a line: tracciando una riga
5. sleeve: manica
6. commodious cellars: ampio alloggiamento
7. hard set: dura
8. bristled: si rizzava
9. firs: abeti
10. knobs: protuberanze
11. carriage: portamento
12. nay: anzi
13. neckcloth: cravatta
14. grasp: presa
15. stubborn: testardo
16. swept with their eyes: percosero con gli occhi
17. the inclined plane of little vessels: il piano inclinato di piccoli recipienti
18. gallons: unità di misura dei liquidi (circa 4,5 litri)
19. full to the brim: pieni fino all'orlo

COMPREHENSION

3 Read the passage and identify the following information.

1. Where does the action take place?
2. What does the speaker want the students to learn?
3. How does the speaker emphasise his idea during the speech?
4. How is the schoolroom described in the passage?
5. What does the speaker compare the children's minds to?

ANALYSIS & INTERPRETATION

4 The name of the protagonist (Gradgrind) is an example of a compound word, i.e. a word that is made up of two different words: Grad (= grade, gradient) + Grind (= to crush, to pulverise). What do these two words make you understand about the character and his attitude towards children and education?

5 In the first paragraph the word 'facts' is repeated many times. Underline them and listen to the speaker's tone of voice while he reads them. Then answer the following questions.

1. What is the effect created? Hammering or mild?
2. How does the listener feel? Intimidated or encouraged?
3. Can you imagine what it would be like to have a teacher like Mr Gradgrind?

6 Focus on the second paragraph and answer the following questions.

1. What is the most recurring adjective used in the description of the speaker?
2. How many times is it repeated?
3. What is the effect created by such an obsessive repetition?
4. Do you think it has a positive connotation if it is applied to a person?

#KEYTOPICS SCIENCE AND TECHNOLOGY

The dangers of fact-based education. The school run by Gradgrind is a grotesque example of an educational institution based on the principles of Utilitarianism (→ p. 275), in which all aspects related to emotions and compassion are banned in favour of an education based on notions, facts, and procedures. Gradgrind translates the 'factory system' into an educational model in which everything aims to turn children into passive workers who become perfectly efficient employees.

REFLECT & DISCUSS

7 In ll. 15-16 Dickens describes Mr Gradgrind's head as a 'warehouse-room for the hard facts stored inside'.

1. What does this expression transform the brain into?
2. What idea of 'learning' emerges from the passage?
 - a. learning is based on the accumulation of notions
 - b. learning implies an element of choice
 - c. creativity is essential for learning

8 How is Gradgrind's school in line with the principles of Utilitarianism? What critical message about Utilitarianism does Dickens convey?

WRITING Lab

9 What do you think about the type of school promoted by Gradgrind? What type of learners does it 'produce'? What would you do to transform it into a school where freedom of thought, critical thinking and emotional intelligence are nurtured? Write your comments in a short text (max. 150 words).

DEBATE

10 You are going to debate the following motion.

Mr Gradgrind is right. School should teach facts and practical knowledge and not waste time on more imaginative but impractical activities.

Divide the class in two teams.

- Team A – the Practicals – will support the motion.
- Team B – the Creatives – will argue against the motion.

Both teams might consider the following ideas.

- In the real world of work, knowledge and the ability to work hard are essential qualities.
- Children have enough time outside school to play and be creative.
- Nothing new can be achieved without freedom and imagination.
- Nothing useful can be achieved without facts, numbers and practical skills.
- School is a preparation for life and life means getting a job and becoming an adult.
- Children today have too much freedom and too little discipline.



↑ Another scene from the BBC version of *Hard Times* (1994) adapted by Peter Barnes.